Arithmetic Coding with Adaptive Context Models

Design and Evaluation of the `acz` File Compressor

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Dedicated to the memory of my colleague Glen G. Langdon

Abstract

The `acz` file compressor combines finite-precision arithmetic coding with adaptive byte models, prediction by partial matching (PPM), and context mixing. Its order-six PPM keeps contexts in a trie stored in two arrays, uses binary escape estimates and information inheritance based on Shkarin's published methods, and codes events with a byte-normalized multi-symbol range coder. The context mixer combines local statistics, bit histories, long matches, and record contexts using integer arithmetic. Independent blocks permit parallel coding, while optional repeat removal carries information across block boundaries. On the twelve-file Silesia development corpus, with one worker per program and memory use not equalized, context mixing produces 42.76 MB from 211.94 MB of input, 12.36% less than `xz -9`. On held-out samples of U.S. Census Bureau data (269.1 GB) and Backblaze hard drive statistics (248.3 GB), it produces 9.89% and 8.40% of input, against 10.49% and 8.76% for `xz -9`. The selected PPM produces 50.60 MB and takes 21.64 seconds to encode and 23.56 seconds to decode. Against the earlier trie model and coder in a balanced experiment, the combined revision reduces bytes by 3.46%, encoding CPU time by 10.69%, and decoding CPU time by 1.87%. It remains 2.80% larger and uses 21.44% and 15.89% more encoding and decoding CPU time than a historical PPMd-H port at the stated settings. These comparisons measure complete configurations, without isolating the cost of any single operation.

I. Introduction

A lossless compressor models regularities in its input and assigns short representations to likely events. Arithmetic coding separates these tasks: a model supplies conditional probabilities, and the coder represents the event sequence using a length close to its cumulative information content. Changing the model can improve compression without changing the coder. This separation follows Langdon and the finite-precision implementations of Witten, Neal, and Cleary and of Moffat, Neal, and Witten [1, 2, 3].

The `arith` library supplies the coding engines, and `acz` divides input into independently coded blocks. Five selectable models range from byte-frequency counts to context mixing. PPM [4] backs off through successively shorter byte contexts, whereas the mixer combines several predictions for each bit. Both learn while coding, so neither requires a probability table in the file header.

PPM needs exact context identity to traverse its escape chain and exclude symbols already considered. `acz` keeps its contexts in a trie whose nodes are linked to their suffixes, after Moffat [13], stored in two arrays and addressed by index. Context mixing uses fixed tables with approximate context identity. The container delimits coded blocks, checks their integrity, bounds the number of live models, and stores incompressible blocks verbatim.

II. Coding Engines

Let $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ be a sequence of model events with probabilities $0 < p_i \le 1$. Its ideal code length is

$$I(x_1, \ldots, x_n) = -\sum_{i=1}^{n} \log_2 p_i. \tag{1}$$

An event can be a byte, a bit, or a PPM escape. Finite-precision coding replaces exact real intervals with integer subintervals. Encoder and decoder must use identical rounding, normalization, and model updates.

A. General Interval Coder

The general coder represents a closed interval $[L, H]$ in a 32-bit coding space. The implementation stores the endpoints and intermediate products in unsigned 64-bit integers. If an event occupies cumulative frequencies $[a, b)$ in a distribution

with total T, let $R = H - L + 1$. The update is

$$L' = L + \left\lfloor \frac{Ra}{T} \right\rfloor, \qquad H' = L + \left\lfloor \frac{Rb}{T} \right\rfloor - 1. \tag{2}$$

Both expressions use the old L. The interface requires $0 \le a < b \le T \le 2^{30}$. Normalization leaves $R > 2^{30}$ before the next event, so every positive frequency receives a nonempty interval. The largest product is at most 2^{62} and fits the intermediate type.

Normalization handles three cases. If the interval lies in the lower half of the coding space, the encoder emits zero. If it lies in the upper half, it emits one and subtracts 2^{31} from both endpoints. If it lies in the middle half, $[2^{30}, 3 \cdot 2^{30})$, the leading bit is still undecided: the encoder subtracts 2^{30} and increments a pending-bit count. After each case it doubles the interval, using $H \leftarrow 2H + 1$ to preserve an inclusive upper endpoint. The process repeats until none of the cases applies.

Pending bits resolve the carry ambiguity without revisiting output. When a later leading bit is known, every pending bit is its complement. For example, emitting a zero after three middle-half steps emits `0111`. This is the standard underflow mechanism of practical arithmetic coding [2].

The decoder maintains a 32-bit code value inside the interval. It converts that value into a cumulative-frequency position, identifies the corresponding model event, and applies the same interval and normalization operations. Its initial read consumes 32 bits; each normalization consumes one more. To match this consumption exactly, termination emits the 32 bits of the final lower endpoint, resolving any pending bits with the first bit, then pads the last output byte with zeros. The container supplies the number of bytes to reconstruct; there is no special end-of-file symbol in the probability model. The decoder also checks the canonical end state and rejects trailing payload. Invalid intervals and I/O failures leave a coder unusable, preventing a caller from continuing from a partially updated state.

B. Binary Range Coder

Bit models use a separate range coder with byte-at-a-time normalization and deferred carry propagation, as discussed by Moffat, Neal, and Witten [3, Sec. 4.2]. Let $p_0 \in (0, 1)$ be the probability of zero. Its fixed-point representation is an integer $P_0 \in \{1, \ldots, 65535\}$, with $p_0 = P_0/65536$. Given the current range R, the split is

$$B = \left\lfloor \frac{RP_0}{65536} \right\rfloor = \lfloor Rp_0 \rfloor. \tag{3}$$

A zero selects the lower range of width B; a one advances the low endpoint by B and selects width $R - B$. Before an event, normalization ensures $R \ge 2^{24}$, making both choices nonempty even at the probability limits. After an event, the coder shifts out whole bytes until the invariant is restored.

A 64-bit low accumulator retains the carry above the 32-bit coding space. A cached output byte and a count of following `0xff` bytes defer publication until the carry is known. Termination performs five byte shifts; the decoder initially reads five bytes and subsequently reads one byte per normalization. The binary interface permits byte-at-a-time normalization and event selection by one comparison. It serves the order-2 model and the context mixer; the general interval coder serves orders 0 and 1.

C. Multi-Symbol Range Coder

PPM uses a separate byte-normalized coder. Following Moffat, Neal, and Witten [3, Sec. 4.4], it first divides the range by the total, $r = \lfloor R/T \rfloor$, then advances the low endpoint by ra. The new width is $r(b - a)$, except for the last interval ($b = T$), which receives the remainder $R - ra$. The decoder keeps its code value relative to the low endpoint and uses two divisions: one to obtain r, and one to obtain a cumulative-frequency target. This differs from Equation (2), including its rounding order.

Before an event, $2^{48} \le R < 2^{56}$ and $T \le 2^{20}$, so $r \ge 2^{28}$. Binary decisions use the upper-part probability $P_1/65536$, with $1 \le P_1 < 65536$, and split at $\lfloor R/65536 \rfloor (65536 - P_1)$. This is division before multiplication, unlike the binary coder above. Normalization shifts whole bytes and defers a carry through a cached byte and following `0xff` bytes. Termination writes eight bytes including the held-back byte. The decoder reads eight bytes initially, rejects an initial relative code value at or above the initial range, and requires a zero relative code value and exact payload consumption at termination. Sink errors latch the encoder into a failed state.

An independent arbitrary-integer reference with immediate output and backward carry propagation matched 165 event sequences, including every nonzero 16-bit binary probability with both outcomes and a carry through 1,024

consecutive `0xff` bytes. Mutation, truncation, and trailing-byte checks covered 540,369 candidates in both debug and release builds. These finite checks support the implementation review; they are not an exhaustive proof. The encoder's one division per interval and the decoder's two are algorithm properties, not an isolated explanation of the timing differences reported below.

III. Adaptive Probability Models

Every model is initialized at the start of a block. Encoder and decoder update its state from the same observed bytes and bits, after using each prediction. This convention permits reconstruction from the compressed stream alone. Table 1 lists the model selected by each level.

Table 1: Models in `acz`. The default is level 4. A byte context contains completed preceding bytes; a bit context additionally includes the current byte's known prefix.

Level	Probability model	Coding engine
0	Adaptive byte frequencies	General interval
1	Byte frequencies conditioned on the preceding byte	General interval
2	Binary predictions conditioned on two preceding bytes	Binary range
3	Prediction by partial matching, maximum byte order 6	Multi-symbol range
4	Context mixing with matches and record contexts	Binary range

A. Orders 0, 1, and 2

Order 0 counts the 256 byte values. A Fenwick tree [6] stores partial sums in an array, supporting cumulative-frequency queries and updates in $O(\log|\Sigma|)$ steps for alphabet Σ. This avoids either scanning all 256 counts for each event or changing every later cumulative total after an observation. Each count starts at one, and an observation adds 32 to the selected count. When the total exceeds 2^{16}, every count is halved, rounding upward. This adaptation threshold discounts older observations before the coder's 2^{30} limit is approached. Order 1 selects one of 256 such distributions using the preceding byte. It can distinguish, for example, letters following a space from letters following another letter, but each distribution receives fewer observations.

Order 2 codes a byte as eight binary decisions, most significant bit first. The context is the preceding two bytes together with the already known bit prefix. The prefix selects a node of a binary tree over the byte alphabet; at each node a compact adaptive estimator predicts the next bit. It starts at probability $1/2$ and moves $1/16$ of the remaining distance toward the observed outcome, with the integer increment rounded down. The stored 16-bit numerator stays in $[15, 65521]$, so both outcomes remain encodable. This avoids searching a 256-symbol distribution, at the expense of eight model and coder operations per byte.

B. Prediction by Partial Matching

PPM predicts a byte from the longest preceding context, of at most six bytes, that has seen it [4]. The contexts are tried from longest to shortest. A context that has not seen the byte codes an escape and passes to the next shorter context, and the symbols it has seen are excluded there: the byte is none of them, so the shorter context need not leave room for them [13]. Below the order-1 contexts is an order-0 distribution over the bytes already seen in the block, and below that a uniform choice among the bytes not yet excluded.

1) Symbol and Escape Weights: A symbol with count f has weight $2f - 1$, Howard and Vitter's method D [22]. Counts are stored in half units, $h = 2f$, so a half-weight update is exact and the coding weight is $h - 1$. The order-0 distribution gives escape the number of visible symbols. Higher contexts use two types of learned estimate based on Shkarin [8].

A context with one symbol and no exclusions codes a binary decision between that symbol and escape. Shkarin's Section 3.1 supplies 8,192 classes: 128 count levels, four shorter-context alphabet-size classes, and four binary flags. Our count quantizer is exact in half units below 64, then has eight levels per octave, saturated at 127. Shorter alphabets are grouped as 1, 2–3, 4–15, and 16 or more symbols. The flags record whether the previous byte's successful event had probability strictly above $1/2$, whether either of the top two bits is set in each of the previous and singleton bytes, and whether more than six successive bytes were coded without escape at probability strictly above $1/2$. The previous-event

test includes order 0. On first use a class starts with escape probability $1/(f+1)$, preserving half counts. Its 16-bit estimate moves $1/64$ of the distance toward the observed outcome, using an arithmetic right shift, and is clamped to $[32, 65504]/65536$.

Larger contexts learn an escape *frequency* t, rather than a common probability, so the same class can supply different probabilities $t/(W+t)$ as its visible symbol-weight sum W changes. With exclusions, 400 classes use the components of Shkarin's Section 3.3. Without exclusions, 200 classes use our selected subset of the components in Section 5.5, instead of the per-context estimator of Section 3.2. Visible alphabet sizes have 25 levels, with 25 or more saturated. The masked classes also test the alphabet increase from the child, the increase to the parent, the previous byte's top bits, and whether the context's mean count $T/(m+1)$ exceeds two. The unmasked classes test $4m > 3m_{\text{parent}}$, the previous byte's top bits, and the long-run flag. These quantizers and thresholds are implementation choices, not a claim to reproduce every PPMII estimator.

Shkarin motivates frequency modeling but does not specify the following update. We apply Robbins and Monro's stochastic-approximation method [9] to an observation we designed; the observation and its integer implementation are ours. For outcome $\delta = 1$ on escape and zero on a symbol, the ideal, unrounded rule is

$$t \leftarrow t + \frac{\delta(W+t) - t}{N_0}. \tag{4}$$

Here W is the pre-decision sum used by the coder, after exclusions. A class starts at the number of visible symbols and keeps 12 fractional bits. Its window is $N_0 = \min(64, 2^{1+\lceil \log_2 \max(4,N) \rceil})$ for N previous uses. Escape adds W/N_0 exactly in fixed point; a hit subtracts the fixed-point value divided by N_0, rounding that decrement down. The learned value stays between $1/16$ and 2^{18}; the coder uses $\max(1, \lfloor t + 1/2 \rfloor)$. Only the ideal unrounded, unclamped rule has zero expected drift at $q = t/(W+t)$ for fixed W and escape rate q. For example, $W = 30$, $N_0 = 64$, and fixed-point value 40961 give an increment of 1920 and decrement of 640: integer drift vanishes at $q = 1/4$, whereas the ideal root is $40961/163841$. Floors, caps and coding-weight rounding further distinguish the implemented estimate.

2) Learning: After coding, the byte is counted in the successful context and added to every longer context that escaped. Update exclusion [13] is modified in one case: the immediate shorter context also receives a half-weight increment while the successful context's *pre-update* symbol count is below eight and its order is below the maximum order six, following Shkarin's Section 2.2. Our mapping uses the stored count f for this cutoff; it does not test the parent's count.

When a symbol is added to a context that already holds others, its initial count uses Shkarin's equation (5), with $\tau = 1/4$, generalized symbol frequency $f - 1/2$, and total frequency $\sum f$. Integer arithmetic rounds the inherited count down in half units and clamps it to $[1, 32]$. A new singleton context delays inheritance until it is next encountered, using its suffix parent's statistics at that time, as described at the end of Section 2.1. Pending singleton ancestors are resolved shortest first before the next coding decision, without reading that decision's input byte. For this new-context case we use the values Shkarin's Section 3.1 gives for binary contexts, $\tau = 1$ and initial escape frequency one; a singleton parent passes on its own count. Applying these values here, the count mappings, rounding and bounds are explicit design choices. A context reset removes pending nodes, while the class learners survive until the next block.

When a context's total stored half count exceeds 8192, counts are halved with upward rounding and a minimum stored count of two, so symbols remain encodable. A symbol whose count passes its predecessor's moves one place forward, keeping frequent symbols near the front. Encoder and decoder perform the same inheritance, rescaling, reordering and reset operations. Independent checks compared exact model-state vectors, including exclusion stamps, over 20 streams with forced resets, stamp rollover and long rescaling sequences; the cleaned model matched its selected experimental predecessor. Such agreement on finite streams does not establish correctness for every reachable state.

C. Context Mixing

PPM chooses a sequence of contexts and backs off; context mixing asks several models for predictions at once. Following Mahoney's PAQ8L and LPAQ1 implementations [14, 15], `acz` combines those predictions in the log-odds domain and learns how much to trust each one.

There are eighteen mixer inputs. Directly indexed order-0 and order-1 counters provide two. Seven hashed context models—byte orders 2, 3, 4, and 6, a word context, and two sparse contexts—each provide two more: an adaptive probability and a probability learned from a bit history. A match model and a constant bias supply the last two. All byte contexts are combined with the current partial byte, so prediction remains causal within a byte.

The word context combines the preceding byte with a running hash of the current run of ASCII letters, folded to lowercase and reset on a non-letter. One sparse context always combines bytes two and four positions back with the current position modulo four. The other follows the record detector described below.

An adaptive counter stores a probability and an observation count n. Its update moves approximately $1/(n + 3.5)$ of the way toward the observed bit. Direct order-0 counters cap n at 60, order-1 counters at 120, and match counters at 1023. These caps keep the learning rate positive. A hashed model instead uses the sum of its two bit-history counts as n, with each count capped at 63. Each observation increments the matching count and reduces the opposing count, when it exceeds two, to half its value plus one, rounding down. This gives recent runs more influence than remote evidence. A learned map converts this state into a second probability. The two inputs distinguish a stable long-established tendency from a similar probability based on little or recently changing evidence.

Figure 1 shows the combination of these predictions into one probability for the next bit.

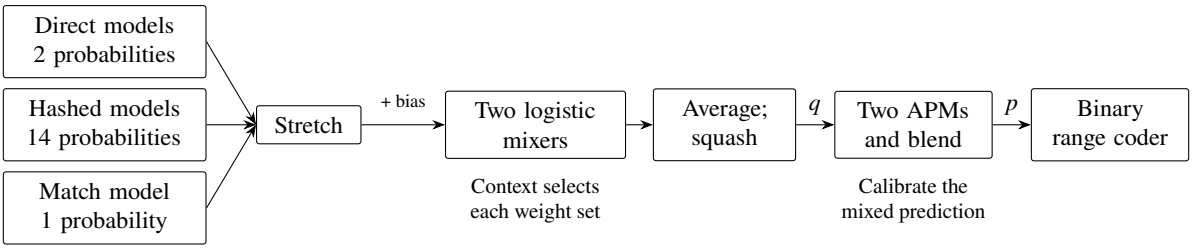


Figure 1: Context mixing for one bit. Seventeen probabilities and a constant bias become one probability through two context-dependent mixtures and two calibration maps. After coding the observed bit, the selected states and weights are trained for the next prediction.

1) Mixing and Calibration: For the seventeen input probabilities $p_i \in (0, 1)$, write $x_i = \ln(p_i/(1 - p_i))$; the eighteenth input is the constant $x_{18} = 1$. An ideal logistic mixer predicts

$$q = \sigma\left(\sum_i w_i x_i\right), \qquad \sigma(z) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-z}}. \tag{5}$$

For an observed bit y, the negative log-likelihood has weight gradient $(q - y)x_i$. The online update therefore takes the form

$$w_i \leftarrow w_i + \eta x_i (y - q). \tag{6}$$

The implementation uses bounded integer weights and table-based approximations to stretch and squash, avoiding platform-dependent floating-point results. Stretched inputs use 256 integer units per unit of log odds, so the ideal bias of one is stored as 256. Two mixers use different weight selections: one is conditioned on the partial byte and four match-length classes (none, 1–15, 16–31, and 32 or more), the other on the preceding byte. Their outputs are averaged in the stretched domain.

Two adaptive probability maps [14] then calibrate the combined prediction. Each map stores a 33-point curve sampled uniformly in the stretched domain and interpolates between adjacent points. One is conditioned on the partial byte; the other also uses the preceding byte. The final estimate blends the mixed prediction and the two calibrated predictions with weights $1, 1, 2$. Let Q, A_0, A_1 be their 12-bit integer numerators, representing probabilities $Q/4096$, $A_0/4096$, and $A_1/4096$. The implementation computes

$$P = \min\left(4095, \max\left(1, \left\lfloor \frac{Q + A_0 + 2A_1 + 2}{4} \right\rfloor\right)\right), \qquad p = \frac{P}{4096}. \tag{7}$$

The addition of two rounds the integer average to the nearest unit. The resulting probability of a one is $p \in [1/4096, 4095/4096]$, so the binary coder uses the zero-probability numerator $P_0 = 65536 - 16P$. After observing the bit, both mixers, the selected calibration points, and the context statistics are trained before the next prediction. This ordering is part of the compressed representation: changing it changes the probabilities seen by the decoder.

2) Long Matches and Records: The match model looks for an earlier occurrence of the recent byte suffix and predicts the continuation after a match of at least six bytes. A hash lookup supplies a candidate, which is confirmed by comparing at most 32 preceding bytes backward. An active match then grows for as long as its continuation agrees, so 32 is a confirmation limit, not a limit on the continuing match length. A counter selected by length class and expected bit turns that prediction into a probability. For length ℓ, the counter class is ℓ through 15 and $\min(31, 15 + \lfloor(\ell - 15)/3\rfloor)$ thereafter, giving finer resolution than the mixer's four classes. The history covers the entire block, allowing this model to exploit repetitions much longer than any fixed byte order. A disagreement with the predicted bits invalidates the current continuation.

The record detector follows PAQ8L's repeated-spacing method [14]. Four equal successive gaps greater than one supply a candidate record length. It tracks two candidates with confirmation counts, replacing the weaker candidate when a new one appears. A candidate different from the current length is adopted at sixteen confirmations, and adoption clears both counts. Once a length is established, one sparse model uses bytes one and two records above the current position together with the preceding byte. Before a record length is known, it uses bytes four and five positions back and the current position modulo four. This captures columns in fixed-width data without a file-type parser. The detector and match model still contribute probabilistic evidence: the mixer can reduce their influence when they predict poorly.

IV. Context Storage and Memory

PPM and context mixing place different demands on their tables. A PPM context determines which symbols are excluded and how the decoder traverses the escape chain, so its identity must be exact. The mixer can tolerate collisions as loss of prediction quality, provided encoder and decoder experience the same collisions. Its tables use fingerprints and replacement to hold memory fixed.

A. The PPM Context Trie

The PPM contexts form a trie [10, Sec. 6.3]. A context is a node, and the symbols it has seen are its children. Symbol s of context c points to the node of cs, the context that follows when s is coded in c; at the maximum order, where cs would be too long, it points to cs without its oldest byte. Every node also points to its suffix, the same context without its oldest byte, which is Moffat's vine pointer [13]. Figure 2 shows both kinds of link.

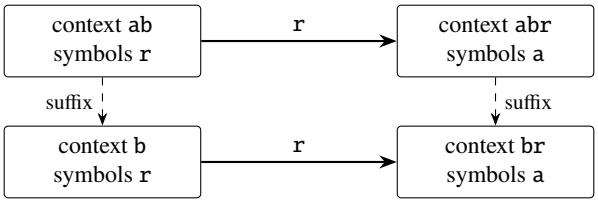


Figure 2: Four contexts after the text `abracadabra`. Solid arrows lead from a symbol to the context that follows it; dashed arrows from a context to its suffix. The suffix of a symbol's successor is the successor of the same symbol in the suffix, so the link from the symbol that coded a byte and the suffix links below it reach every context of the next byte.

Coding a byte starts at the longest context and follows suffix links only as far as escapes require. Once the byte is coded, the symbol it was found as leads to the next byte's longest context. Ordinary coding therefore never searches for a context by its bytes; a table keyed by context bytes would look up as many as six contexts for each byte. Section VI-E retains the comparison of the earlier estimator with both stores.

One link suffices because of a property of update exclusion: it changes how often each context counts a symbol, but not which symbols a context holds. The first time s follows a context c, no longer context ending in c can have seen s, so every one of them escapes and c receives s along with them. Hence c holds s exactly when the string cs has occurred, and from the next byte on the context cs exists and is linked from s. The successor of the symbol that coded a byte is thus always the longest context of the next byte. When a byte creates contexts, each is linked from the symbol that the previous byte was learned as in the context one order shorter.

Storage is bounded by restarting the model. When the next byte's updates could exceed 2^{24} symbol slots or 6,291,454 contexts, every context and count is discarded; the preceding bytes and the learned SEE and binary probabilities are kept, and the byte is then learned as if new. Encoder and decoder reach this decision from identical state, so no restart marker is transmitted. The contexts created at a restart are those of the current history, all at once, without the shorter

contexts that would lead to them. Each is kept on a list of at most five until the symbol that leads to it is added; this list is the only place where contexts are compared by their bytes.

A node takes 12 bytes: its suffix, a link, its total count, its number of symbols, and, for a context of one symbol, that symbol, whose count is the total and whose successor is the link. A context of one symbol, the commonest kind at the longer orders, therefore needs no other storage. A context with more symbols links to an array of 8-byte slots, each holding a byte, its count, and its successor, with room for the next power of two. An array that a context outgrows goes on a free list of its size and is reused before the arena grows [11, Sec. 2.5]. Nodes and slots are addressed by 32-bit indices, so the representation does not depend on pointer width or structure layout.

For a block of n bytes the model reserves $\min(2^{24}, 24n)$ slots and $\min(6\,291\,454, 6n) + 7$ nodes, the most it can use: each byte adds at most six contexts and six symbols, and a context that comes to hold k symbols has taken arrays of fewer than $4k$ slots in all. At the default block size this is about 200 MiB. The arrays are reserved once and never move. A restart empties them but keeps their storage.

B. Fixed Tables for Context Mixing

Each hashed CM table is an array of 64-byte buckets. A bucket holds metadata and fifteen states, the internal nodes of a four-bit prediction tree. Looking up once per nibble supplies the states needed for four successive bit predictions, reducing hashing and memory traffic. Two adjacent candidate buckets are examined using a fingerprint. On a miss, the less-used bucket is reset for the new context; aging the other use count prevents once-frequent contexts from retaining a place indefinitely.

Fingerprints and replacement bound storage and lookup cost. A fingerprint collision can combine unrelated statistics, and replacement forgets old observations. Neither affects losslessness because both sides repeat the same operations. The fixed allocation avoids growth work in the prediction loop, while two-way lookup limits the number of candidate buckets examined.

V. File Format and Execution

The current format (version 13) stores independently modeled blocks, by default 16 MiB each. Figure 3 shows the stages. Models restart at block boundaries, allowing workers to code blocks without sharing prediction state. The writer preserves input order regardless of worker completion order.

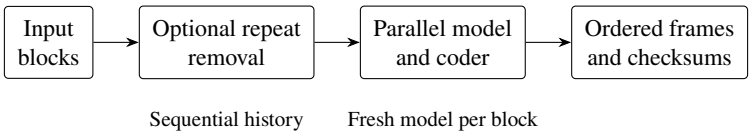


Figure 3: Compression pipeline. Decoding reverses the stages: block decoding may run in parallel, while ordered reconstruction applies repeat references to the preceding output.

A. Framing and Error Detection

A 16-byte file header identifies the format and model parameters. Each ordinary block has a one-byte kind, two four-byte lengths, a payload, and an eight-byte CRC-64. The checksum covers block identity and framing as well as payload. A one-byte end marker and a 16-byte trailer record the total decoded length and a CRC-64 of the reconstructed stream. These checks distinguish truncated or corrupted data from a valid arithmetic stream of the wrong length; CRCs provide error detection, not authentication.

If model coding does not reduce a block's size, the compressor stores that block verbatim. Without repeat removal, the resulting expansion bound is 17 bytes per block plus 33 bytes per file. The decoder validates lengths and kinds before allocating buffers and requires the coded payload to terminate consistently with the declared output length. Concatenated members are processed in sequence.

The command-line tool stages file output in the destination directory, flushes and synchronizes it, and publishes it only after successful completion. Without replacement permission, publication must not overwrite an existing destination; with replacement enabled, rename provides the final switch. Source removal, when requested, follows successful publication. Streaming to standard output has the usual streaming semantics: an error may follow an already written prefix.

Version 13 rejects earlier versions at each member boundary, before allocating a model. Private version 12 was never released and was used by two incompatible experimental PPM payloads; its number is not reused. A separate check rejected 47 samples from both variants, standalone and following a valid empty version-13 member, with one and two workers: 188 explicit unsupported-version errors with empty output. The previous private decoder and its original samples remain available for historical reproduction. Public version-11 files require the 0.5.0 decoder. Header-only identity between the measured new payload and version 13 does not imply cross-version decoding support.

B. Worker Admission

The pipeline bounds the number of submitted but unfinished blocks. Completed blocks that are waiting for an earlier block still occupy a slot, so an out-of-order result queue cannot grow with the input size. Admission accounts for a model's maximum storage, rather than its smaller initial allocation. For ordinary coding with block size B and model allowance M, the single-worker path reserves approximately $M + 2B$; the parallel path reserves $M + 4B$ per worker for the active, queued, and returned buffers.

At the default block size, a parallel CM worker is allowed about 213 MiB and a PPM worker about 264 MiB. A 4 GiB budget therefore admits at most nineteen CM workers or fifteen PPM workers before other options reduce the allowance. PPM reserves its arrays at block initialization; blocks of 512 KiB or less reserve less. These are implementation storage bounds used to choose concurrency, not measurements of process resident memory; allocator and runtime overhead are separate. On Linux, the detected budget respects every visible applicable cgroup v2 memory limit, including ancestor limits exposed through overlapping mounts; a subtree mount must not hide a tighter limit visible through a broader mount.

C. Optional Long-Repeat Removal

Independent blocks forget earlier model state. The optional `--dedup` stage addresses exact repetitions across those boundaries by maintaining a 256 MiB window of original input. A Karp–Rabin-style rolling fingerprint [16] over 32 bytes samples candidate anchors, held in a direct-mapped table. Matches of at least 256 bytes become length–distance copy commands; unmatched bytes form a literal residual that is passed to the selected probability model. Differential compression similarly separates repeated regions from residual information [18].

The format stores each block's commands either as unsigned LEB128 variable-length integers [17, Sec. 7.6] or as a structured binary range code, choosing the smaller representation and adding a one-byte selector. The structured form codes the copy count, each literal run, each copy distance or its index among the four most recent distances, each copy length less 256, and the final literal run. A number's bit length is coded through a six-bit adaptive tree; up to four bits below its leading one use adaptive models conditioned on that length, and the remaining bits use probability one half. These command models restart for each block. The decoder rejects bit lengths above 37 and copy counts above the block length divided by 256 before using them, then checks the reconstructed command list. The selector raises the expansion bound with repeat removal to 29 bytes per block plus 33 bytes per file.

The encoder searches only already available history. The decoder requires each copy distance d to satisfy $0 < d \le \min(W, P)$, where W is the window and P the number of bytes reconstructed so far. Overlapping copies are valid: each copied byte refers to an earlier output position, so repeated patterns can extend beyond the original match. Reconstruction is sequential even when residual decoding runs in parallel.

Repeat removal is off by default. It adds command and history storage, and deleting a repeated span changes the adjacency seen by the statistical model. Fewer literal bytes therefore need not mean fewer compressed bytes. Both the matching rule and the command representation affect the result: on Silesia, raw commands slightly increase CM's output, whereas the coded representation makes it slightly smaller (Section VI-J). Its value depends on the prevalence and distance of long exact repeats.

VI. Evaluation

The Silesia measurements compare compressed size and encoding and decoding CPU time across the five `acz` models and four established compressors. Aggregate totals measure storage and computational cost for the corpus; per-file results show how the models respond to different input types. All configurations use a single worker, so these measurements do not assess parallel scaling. Section VI-G measures compressed size on two collections not used in development.

A. Method

The evaluation uses the Silesia compression corpus [19], a collection designed to test lossless compressors on varied data larger than the files in earlier benchmarks. Its twelve files include English and Polish texts, XML, source code, an application distribution, an executable, medical images, and databases. Their sizes range from 5.35 to 51.22 MB, totaling 211,938,580 bytes; Table 3 identifies each file. This mixture exercises both local symbol regularities and longer repeated structures.

Each file is compressed separately, without shared history. The CPU-time experiments use the same NVIDIA DGX Spark computer, whose GB10 processor contains ten Cortex-X925 and ten Cortex-A725 CPU cores. Each process is pinned to one Cortex-X925 core, identified by Linux as logical CPU 7. Each timed configuration is run three times on that core. For each repetition, user and system CPU times are summed over all twelve files; the reported time is the median of those three sums. Every encode and decode must exit successfully, and every reconstructed file is compared byte-for-byte with its input.

The `acz` configurations use 16 MiB blocks and one worker; both ordinary CM and CM with repeat removal are included. Comparators are XZ Utils 5.4.5 at `-9 -T1`, Zstandard 1.5.5 at `-19 -T1`, bzip2 1.0.8 at `-9`, and gzip 1.12 at `-9`. The Rust build uses rustc 1.96.0, release optimization, link-time optimization, and one code-generation unit. Sizes include file-format overhead. The measurements compare complete compressor configurations at these specified settings, not settings matched for equal memory or equal time. The retained rows, input hashes, run scripts, and build identities accompany the report; its tables are generated from those rows.

Level 3 uses the selected five model changes and the multi-symbol range coder. It was measured in run 5 against the earlier trie build and a historical PPMd-H port, with three repetitions and a Latin-square order: each build appears in each position twelve times across the corpus. This is not all six permutations. Each attempt records a filtered process snapshot before starting; no competing process was recorded on core 7 in those snapshots. They do not establish continuous exclusive occupancy. Source, binary and input identities were independently captured after the run. The runner checks reconstructed bytes and hashes containers before deleting its temporary outputs. A separate local reproduction generated all twelve recorded new-container hashes and independently decoded them. Table 5 presents all three builds from this experiment.

Run 5 timed snapshot `c7aef7e0`, which emitted private format 12. The selected version 13 changes only the version byte and header CRC relative to those measured containers; the complete model and coder are unchanged apart from comments. All twelve retained version-12/version-13 pairs were independently hashed, their headers checked with a separate bit-at-a-time CRC calculation, and matching version-13 copies decoded to the independently hashed inputs. This is payload and size identity evidence, not a new timing run. The committed integration `0d8dace` matches the reviewed version-13 source snapshot.

The other `acz` configurations retain the original measurements. Their models and coders are unchanged; without repeat removal only version framing changes. The row for CM with repeat removal used the earlier raw command representation; the current coded form is evaluated for size only (Section VI-J). As a separate reference, 7-Zip 23.01's PPMd [5] was timed on the same core with order 6, a 256 MiB model, and one thread; it codes each file whole, without `acz`'s 16 MiB blocks. It is distinct from run 5's block-based port. These are measurements of identified builds, not a claim that every configuration was retimed together. Silesia was used throughout development, including model selection, and is not held out.

The earlier four-repetition trie-versus-hash experiment remains separate (Section VI-E). New model-selection size experiments are described below. The second mixer and record detection were not individually ablated. A separate experiment varies only the repeat-removal threshold and measures size, not CPU performance.

B. Aggregate Compression and Time

Table 2 reports the size of all twelve compressed files and the CPU time to encode and decode them. Among these timed configurations, CM produces the smallest aggregate output: 42,764,432 bytes, or 20.18% of input. This is 12.36% smaller than `xz -9`. The improvement requires substantially more computation: CM encoding takes 2.57 times the CPU time of XZ, and decoding takes about 107 times as much.

PPM occupies an intermediate point among the `acz` models. It produces 50,601,960 bytes, 4.57% less than `zstd -19`, and encodes in 21.64 seconds. Compared with CM, it is 18.33% larger but provides 7.58 times the encoding throughput and 7.24 times the decoding throughput. Each of its three corpus encoding totals is 21.64 seconds at the recorded precision; decoding totals span 23.54–23.57 seconds. 7-Zip's PPMd produces 3.11% fewer bytes and takes

Table 2: Silesia timing experiments, sorted by compressed size. Level 3 and 7-Zip's PPMd come from their own experiments (Section VI-A). CPU seconds are medians of whole-corpus sums of user plus system time, over three repetitions for each selected row. Lower is better in every numeric column.

Configuration	Compressed bytes	% of input	Encode (s)	Decode (s)
acz -4 (CM)	42,764,432	20.18	164.07	170.55
acz -4 + repeats (raw commands)	42,796,316	20.19	156.43	161.85
xz -9	48,795,480	23.02	63.89	1.60
7-Zip PPMd -o6	49,029,343	23.13	15.77	16.90
acz -3 (PPM)	50,601,960	23.88	21.64	23.56
zstd -19	53,024,529	25.02	60.52	0.18
bzip2 -9	54,506,769	25.72	9.22	3.96
gzip -9	67,631,918	31.91	11.37	0.75
acz -2	69,610,084	32.84	6.31	9.55
acz -1	94,356,023	44.52	8.69	9.60
acz -0	127,167,804	60.00	9.92	10.48

15.77 and 16.90 seconds; Section VI-E discusses the difference. Zstandard decodes far faster than either statistical model.

Order 2 is the fastest `acz` encoder in this experiment, taking 6.31 seconds and producing 32.84% of the original size. It improves both size and encoding time over the byte-oriented lower levels. The lower levels use smaller models and produce more compressed bytes than PPM or CM.

With the raw command representation in the original timing experiment, repeat removal changes the CM total from 42,764,432 to 42,796,316 bytes, an increase of 0.075%. Encoding time falls by 4.66% and decoding time by 5.10%. Across the three repetitions, CM encoding totals range from 164.01 to 164.10 seconds and decoding totals from 170.50 to 170.58 seconds; with repeat removal, the ranges are 156.39–156.48 and 161.72–162.13 seconds, respectively. The modest size loss is consistent with command overhead and changed residual contexts offsetting the benefit of removing repeats. These timings do not measure the later command coder.

Figure 4 places the five configurations used in the per-file comparison on the size–time plane. CM occupies the smallest-size end, PPM lies between CM and the simple bit model in both directions, and the dictionary compressors separate strongly from both during decoding.

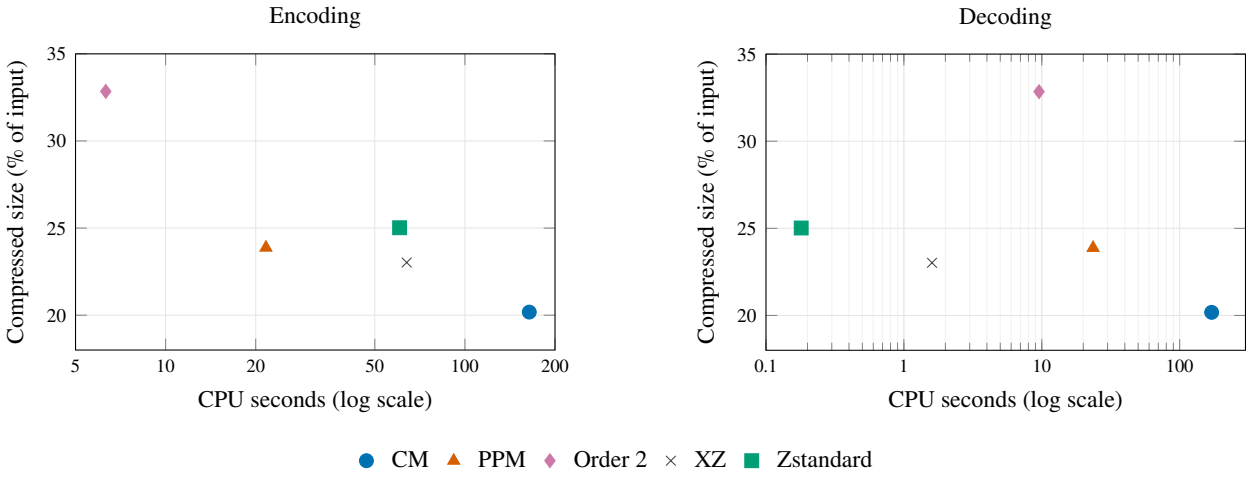


Figure 4: Compression size versus encoding and decoding CPU time for five configurations from Table 2. Lower and farther left is better. The horizontal axes are logarithmic; the vertical axes share a linear scale.

C. Why Decoding Remains Expensive

CM takes 170.55 seconds to decode the corpus, compared with 164.07 seconds to encode it; PPM takes 23.56 and 21.64 seconds, respectively. Both directions perform adaptive modeling, although their symbol-selection and coding costs differ. The compressed stream supplies coding decisions, but it does not supply the probability distributions needed to interpret them. The decoder reconstructs those distributions from the decoded prefix and must reproduce the encoder's model updates before proceeding.

For each output byte, CM makes eight binary decisions. Each decision uses eighteen mixer inputs, two learned weighted sums, and two interpolated probability maps. After resolving the bit, the decoder updates the counters, bit histories, mixer weights, and probability maps. Hash-bucket selection is shared over four bits, but prediction and training still occur for every bit. Completing a byte also advances the match model, word context, and record detector. Thus a short code string can require substantial model work to reconstruct a long output.

PPM works at byte granularity, but a byte can require several escape decisions. The decoder follows suffix links from the longest context, computes visible symbol totals under exclusion, and searches the successful context's cumulative weights for the symbol. It then updates the successful and longer contexts, the learned escape estimates, and any new contexts and symbol arrays. The trie removes the search for contexts, but not this adaptive work. The timings measure the complete paths, without attributing fractions of runtime to individual operations or memory accesses.

Dictionary compressors have a different asymmetry. Their encoders search for useful matches, while their decoders receive literal and length–distance commands and reconstruct matches by copying already decoded bytes [20, 21]. CM's match model instead contributes a probability: it does not let the ordinary CM decoder copy an entire matched string in one step. The optional repeat-removal stage can provide such copy commands, but it has little benefit on this corpus.

Levels 3 and 4 therefore suit workloads that give compressed size substantial weight and can afford decoding CPU time. In these measurements, level 4 buys the smallest total size, while level 3 gives up some compression for 7.58 times the encoding throughput and 7.24 times the decoding throughput. Neither is the appropriate default choice for a workload whose primary requirement is fast decompression; the per-file results also show that the stronger models do not win on every input. Adaptive reconstruction explains the work required in both directions, but does not determine its implementation cost: the earlier complete trie redesign and the later model-and-coder revision measure different changes, as the next sections describe.

D. Variation Across Files

Table 3 gives per-file compressed fractions. CM produces fewer bytes than XZ on each file, with a different reduction for each input. The aggregate in Table 2 is obtained by summing bytes, so larger files contribute proportionally more. On `x-ray`, PPM is slightly larger than order 2, whereas on `sao` it is now smaller. On `dickens`, PPM is slightly smaller than CM. The chemical database and XML file fall below 10% of input under PPM and below 7% under CM. The extra model work therefore buys different amounts of compression on different inputs.

Figure 5 shows the compression profile of each configuration across the twelve files: the largest separation appears on some structured inputs, while the star catalog remains relatively difficult for all five.

Table 3: Per-file compressed sizes as percentages of the original. Input sizes use decimal MB. PPM is level 3 and CM is level 4; repeat removal is disabled.

File	Contents	Input MB	Order 2	PPM	CM	XZ	Zstd
dickens	English text	10.19	35.33	22.83	22.84	27.77	27.96
mozilla	Application files	51.22	40.84	32.61	24.96	26.11	29.51
mr	MR image	9.97	24.63	23.23	22.51	27.58	31.22
nci	Chemical database	33.55	16.66	7.07	4.54	5.18	5.03
ooffice	Executable	6.15	52.15	42.42	35.25	39.45	42.24
osdb	Database	10.09	36.85	24.14	23.38	28.26	30.72
reymont	Polish text (PDF)	6.63	24.66	17.21	15.70	19.87	20.33
samba	Source code	21.61	29.28	19.93	15.16	17.42	18.08
sao	Star catalog	7.25	67.40	66.60	58.61	60.88	68.95
webster	Dictionary (HTML)	41.46	29.74	17.11	16.10	20.23	20.97
x-ray	X-ray image	8.47	46.33	46.65	44.22	52.98	60.84
xml	XML	5.35	19.10	9.60	6.85	8.48	8.51

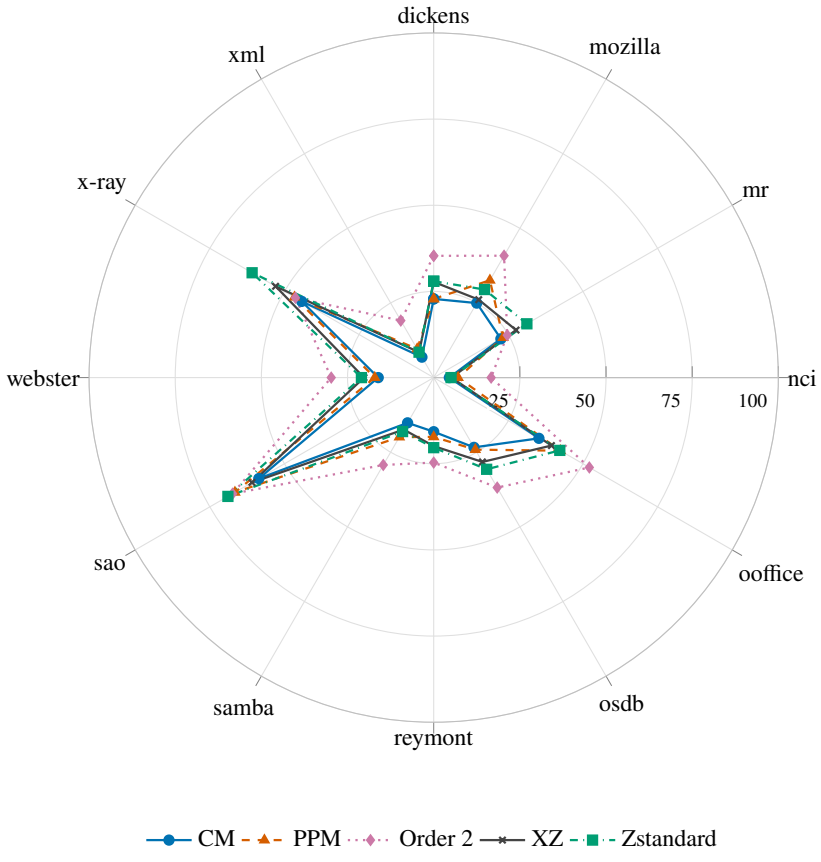


Figure 5: Compression across the Silesia files. Each spoke is one file; radius is compressed size as a percentage of input, from 0% at the center to 100% at the outer ring. Smaller radii mean better compression.

E. Earlier Trie versus Hashed Contexts

Before the model changes and multi-symbol coder described above, the earlier probability model was built with its contexts in a hash table, grown by linear hashing [12] and keyed by each context's bytes. For every byte it looks up the context of each order, and each context keeps its symbols in an array of its own. The trie build also codes each single-symbol decision with the coder's shift rather than its division, which gives the same intervals, and it allocates and reuses symbol arrays differently. The estimator and its update rules are the same, so both code the same intervals until one of them restarts; after a restart at a different byte, their states and work differ. The two builds ran alternately on the same core, four times each over the corpus, each first in two repetitions (Table 4).

Table 4: Historical run 3: the earlier PPM model with two context stores, on Silesia. These are not timings of the current estimator or coder. Times are medians of four corpus sums; peak resident memory is the largest of any one file's process.

Measure	Hash table	Trie
Encoding CPU (s)	54.59	24.42
Decoding CPU (s)	53.03	23.93
Encoding elapsed (s)	54.66	24.50
Decoding elapsed (s)	53.14	24.01
Largest peak RSS, encoding (MiB)	295	133
Largest peak RSS, decoding (MiB)	292	133
Compressed bytes	52,458,591	52,413,478

With the trie build, encoding takes 55.3% less CPU time and decoding 54.9% less, and the maximum peak resident memory of any one process falls from 295 to 133 MiB. Of the 19 blocks, 11 restart in neither model, and their code strings are identical. The trie uses fewer symbol slots, because a context of one symbol keeps it in its node and outgrown arrays are reused; it restarts 14 times against the hash table's 16, and its output is 45,113 bytes smaller. These figures measure the complete change: context navigation, storage and allocation, the coding of single-symbol decisions, and the restart positions that follow from them. The experiment does not divide the difference among them.

For the current selected level 3 in Table 2, the separate whole-file 7-Zip PPMd reference produces 3.11% fewer bytes, and level 3 takes 1.37 and 1.39 times its encoding and decoding time. The two differ in their estimators and memory policies as well as in `acz`'s 16 MiB blocks, so this comparison measures complete configurations, not context storage alone.

F. Selected Model and Coder

Table 5 compares the selected implementation with the preceding trie and with the historical port in run 5. The new model and coder together produce 3.456% fewer bytes than the trie baseline and use 10.689% less encoding CPU time and 1.874% less decoding CPU time. Against the port they produce 2.797% more bytes and use 21.437% and 15.888% more encoding and decoding CPU time. The port is `debc62e`, format 10. Its level-3 model and coder are those of public release 0.5.0: their sources differ only in a dedication comment. Users upgrading from 0.5.0 should therefore expect about 2.8% larger level-3 files on this corpus at matching settings with repeat removal off. The retained version-10/version-11 identity checks preserve the tested payloads and sizes in that configuration. The increased CPU costs above are measured against `debc62e`; the complete format-11 release 0.5.0 executable was not timed here. Equal block sizes do not equalize estimators, memory policies or restarts.

Table 5: Run 5, Silesia: the selected five model changes and multi-symbol coder (New), the preceding trie (Trie), and historical port (Port). Times are medians of three whole-corpus sums. RSS is the maximum observed peak of an individual process, not model allocation. All use 16 MiB blocks and one worker. New was timed as private format 12; format 13 was checked separately for header-only changes.

Measure	New	Trie	Port
Compressed bytes	50,601,960	52,413,478	49,224,897
Encoding CPU (s)	21.64	24.23	17.82
Decoding CPU (s)	23.56	24.01	20.33
Encoding elapsed (s)	21.72	24.30	17.89
Decoding elapsed (s)	23.62	24.09	20.41
Maximum encoding peak RSS (KiB)	136,344	136,560	148,900
Maximum decoding peak RSS (KiB)	136,400	136,620	148,900

This experiment changes both the model and the coder; it does not isolate their individual time costs. In particular, it supplies neither a percentage "model overhead" nor a measured attribution of the decoding difference to division count. The earlier range-coder experiment used a decoder later found to accept noncanonical initial values; its timings remain evidence of that original binary and are not relabeled as measurements of the corrected or current coder. Similarly, the earlier roughly 55-second hashed model and roughly 18-second port differed in several components. That historical gap is not a measurement of hashing cost.

G. Held-Out Collections

Silesia guided development, so two collections of public tabular data that were not used during development measure compressed size elsewhere. The Census collection is a mirror of the U.S. Census Bureau's public data files: 996,923 files totaling 2.46 TB. Its sample is stratified over nineteen file types, among them CSV and other text files, dBase tables, Excel workbooks, SAS data sets, KML, and gzip and ZIP archives. A 152-file pilot set each type's sample size so that the type's geometric mean of the ratio of `acz` size to `xz -9` size would be estimated within 1% at 95% confidence; pilot files are excluded. The Backblaze collection is Backblaze's published hard drive statistics, one CSV file per day and quarterly ZIP archives of those files; its sample is 651 of the 4,830 daily files and 37 of the 45 archives. Both samples were drawn with fixed seeds before measurement. One sampled Census file is empty and is excluded.

Each input is copied to the measuring host. A gzip file is decompressed and a ZIP archive's members are concatenated in archive order; the result is what each program compresses. Each program compresses each input whole with one

thread: `acz -4 -T1`, `acz -3 -T1`, `xz -9 -T1`, and `zstd -19 -T1`, using the XZ Utils and Zstandard versions of Section VI-A. Every output was decompressed and compared byte for byte with its input. The `acz -4`, `xz -9`, `zstd -19`, and release 0.5.0 level-3 rows come from build `debc62e`; level 4 is unchanged since that build, and without repeat removal only version framing differs. The selected level 3 was measured as `a3c9440`, format 13, in a second pass over the same lists, and the SHA-256 of every input agrees between the passes. The measurements ran on NVIDIA DGX Spark hosts with several inputs in progress at once, so only sizes are reported. Totals sum each program's output over the measured files and divide by their total size; they are not estimates for the complete collections.

Table 6: Held-out collections: each program's total compressed size as a percentage of total input over the measured files. Input is in decimal gigabytes. Lower is better.

Collection	Files	GB	`acz -4`	`xz -9`	`zstd -19`	0.5.0 `-3`	`acz -3`
Census	11,058	269.1	9.89	10.49	11.12	12.97	13.60
Backblaze	688	248.3	8.40	8.76	9.13	10.10	10.61

CM produces the smallest output on both collections, 5.7% and 4.0% less than `xz -9`. Both level-3 models produce more bytes than `xz -9` and `zstd -19` on these collections. The selected PPM is 4.9% and 5.0% larger than release 0.5.0's level 3, against 2.80% on Silesia.

H. Model Selection on Development Files

The model experiments used Calgary, Canterbury, large Canterbury and enwik8: 33 file entries totaling 117,221,759 bytes. Calgary's `pic` and Canterbury's `ptt5` have identical content, so the aggregate counts that content twice and has 32 unique inputs. Enwik8 accounts for 85.308% of the input bytes. These were development corpora, not unseen validation data. The selected model combines binary escape classes, the immediate-parent half update, inheritance into existing contexts, class-based escape-frequency learning, and delayed inheritance for new contexts.

Table 7 shows individual and combined changes from three frozen development runs. All use the older general interval coder and report raw code bytes, without production container framing. The escape-probability learner Q shares a probability across a class; F instead learns the frequency t and uses each context's visible W. They are alternatives, not two simultaneously enabled estimates. Run 11 uses source `a8a56841`, run 13 uses `d1c04ca3`, and run 18 uses `c9b15f27`. Independently captured output hashes agree for every configuration shared across these runs and run 21, including all baseline outputs. Individual savings do not add to the combined saving: the features change the counts, contexts and decisions seen by subsequent features.

Table 7: Component size ablations on the 33 development entries. The original rows retain every configuration and per-file result, including regressions. These are size experiments, not comparative timings.

Run	Configuration	Raw code bytes
11	Earlier model	28,863,347
11	Parent half update (P)	28,828,919
11	Binary escape classes (B)	28,790,576
11	Inheritance into existing contexts (I)	28,781,888
11	Class escape-probability learner (Q)	28,446,054
11	B + P	28,754,487
11	B + P + I	28,647,509
11	B + P + I + Q	28,245,639
13	Class escape-frequency learner (F)	27,863,485
13	B + P + I + F	27,625,729
18	B + P + I + F + immediate new inheritance	27,569,661
18	B + P + I + F + delayed new inheritance	27,522,780

The four-part B+P+I+Q model regresses against the baseline on `geo`, `trans`, `grammar.lsp` and `sum`. Replacing Q by F leaves only `geo` larger; delayed inheritance reduces that regression but does not remove it. These aggregate and per-file changes show the effects of the selected configurations, without identifying a unique cause such as class

collisions or learning speed. Comparing modeled code length with a best fixed probability per class would not by itself distinguish those causes, especially when inheritance changes the decision stream and W.

Table 8 retains run 21's four configurations, all using the same frozen experimental source `c60f81f4` and old coder. Across runs 11, 13, 18 and 21, all 759 retained output contents and all input entries were independently rehashed after the runs. The original harness checked every reconstructed byte and canonical termination; the independent audits did not re-decode these outputs. Their fixed-order, single size-run encode and verification columns are not used as comparative CPU timings.

Table 8: Run 21 model-selection sizes, with the old coder. The change column is relative to the earlier trie model. EE1 denotes our Section 3.2 approximation.

Configuration	Raw code bytes	Change
Earlier trie model	28,863,347	+0.000%
EE1 alone	28,203,455	-2.286%
Selected five changes	27,522,780	-4.645%
Selected five plus EE1	27,508,993	-4.692%

The selected five changes reduce the raw total by 4.645%, with one regression: `geo` grows from 55,660 to 56,683 bytes (1.838%). EE1 adds the new-symbol updates of Shkarin's Section 3.2 but approximates the starting calculation by taking the first symbol's rank as zero; it does not implement the paper's full numerical averaging over first-arrival ranks. Adding it saves 13,787 bytes (0.050%) in aggregate but worsens 31 of the 33 entries. Only enwik8 and `world192.txt` improve, by 28,730 and 296 bytes. We selected the five changes with EE1 off and retained the rejected result. These observations do not show that the full paper initializer is inferior. They also do not isolate the remaining difference from the port, whose complete containers and policies differ from this raw-code experiment.

I. Minimum Copy Length

The minimum accepted repeat trades saved model work against copy-command overhead and the changed statistics of the literal residual. To examine compressed size, a separate pilot varies the minimum from 32 to 64, 128, and 256 bytes, with repeat removal disabled as a control. It processes all twelve Silesia inputs with CM. The block size remains 16 MiB, the window 256 MiB, the fingerprint length 32 bytes, and the sparse anchor rule unchanged. A 32-byte minimum therefore does not constitute an exhaustive search for every 32-byte repeat.

The pilot uses raw command varints, predating the command coder. It retains a frozen source snapshot and records the result for every block at every threshold. Every coded residual is decoded and its commands reconstruct the original block. Reported sizes sum the coded or stored body, command bytes, variable-length fields, and ordinary block/file framing; the harness does not serialize a complete checksummed archive for every candidate. The disabled-stage total agrees with the full-program corpus total, as does the 256-byte total. The recorded local wall times are excluded from the CPU-time comparison because the pilot ran under different conditions.

Table 9: Minimum-copy size pilot on Silesia with CM. Projected container bytes include commands and framing.

Minimum copy (bytes)	CM bytes	Command bytes
Off	42,764,432	0
32	46,570,561	4,400,721
64	43,915,907	1,543,987
128	43,014,763	505,225
256	42,796,316	189,663

The 32-byte setting removes 51.77 MB of input but spends 4.40 MB on commands, compared with 15.20 MB removed and 0.19 MB of commands at 256 bytes. Its final output is larger. A 128-byte minimum also enlarges the output, by 218,447 bytes (0.51%) relative to 256. The default remains 256 bytes with repeat removal disabled. These results describe this corpus and these anchor rules; they establish neither a universally optimal threshold nor a CPU-time

advantage for a shorter minimum. Adopting a shorter minimum would also require updating the command-buffer memory bound.

J. Coding the Repeat Commands

A separate full-container experiment tests the coded commands, compiled with rustc 1.93.1. It holds the minimum copy length at 256 bytes, the window at 256 MiB, the block size at 16 MiB, and the worker count at one. All twelve inputs have the same SHA-256 identities as the timing corpus. Each container is decoded and compared byte-for-byte; retained rows record its complete size and hash. Table 10 reports this size and correctness experiment, with no CPU-time claim.

Table 10: Full-container Silesia sizes for CM with coded repeat commands. The no-repeat baseline is the original CM measurement; an independent check of 70 cases across all five historical models found the output unchanged after the header by command coding when repeat removal is disabled. That experiment predates the current PPM model and coder.

Model	No repeats (bytes)	Coded repeats (bytes)	Bytes saved
CM	42,764,432	42,740,598	23,834

Coding the commands saves 55,718 bytes relative to the 256-byte raw-command pilot projection. With repeat removal, CM is 0.056% smaller than its no-repeat baseline. This reverses the small size penalty of raw commands without changing the matched spans or residual model. The 70-case identity check covers empty, one-byte, 256-byte alphabet, pseudorandom, periodic, text, and multi-block inputs at two block sizes. It supports retaining the earlier dedup-off sizes for the unchanged models, but does not establish equal runtime or identity with the new PPM payload. Neither the earlier repeat-removal timings nor the shorter-threshold projections are measurements of the command coder. The stage remains disabled by default, pending evidence from broader workloads.

VII. Related Work

Arithmetic coding's model–coder separation is developed by Langdon [1]. Witten, Neal, and Cleary describe a finite-precision implementation with interval scaling and pending underflow bits [2]; Moffat, Neal, and Witten revisit the interaction between coding precision, probability representation, and practical efficiency [3]. The `arith` engines provide multi-symbol and binary event interfaces.

Cleary and Witten introduce adaptive prediction with partial string matching [4]. Moffat develops practical PPM implementation techniques [13], among them update exclusion and a context trie with vine pointers, which the trie here keeps in two arrays in the manner of Knuth's tries stored as tables [10]. Howard and Vitter study arithmetic-coding models and estimation rules [22]; Bloom and Shkarin develop escape estimation and information inheritance [7, 8]. Shkarin's PPMd [8], in 7-Zip's implementation [5], is the reference PPM of Section VI-E.

Mahoney's 2005 report describes adaptive linear weighting in the earlier PAQ family [23]. PAQ8L and LPAQ1 use the later log-odds mixing architecture and learned probability calibration [14, 15]. The `acz` mixer's word, match, and record contexts express different forms of regularity within that framework. Integer arithmetic and fixed-size tables make the complete prediction process deterministic and bounded. The long-repeat stage is related to differential compression's representation of a target through references and unmatched material [18]; the reference is the already reconstructed prefix of the same stream.

XZ uses LZMA2, which combines dictionary matching with range coding [20]; Zstandard combines dictionary matching with Huffman and finite-state entropy coding [21]. Their decoding paths reconstruct matches without repeating the statistical model training performed by PPM and context mixing.

VIII. Conclusion

The `acz` design combines adaptive models and coding engines with different compression–time tradeoffs. Adaptive byte distributions, bit models, PPM, and context mixing share a block-oriented container. PPM keeps exact context relationships in a trie stored in two arrays and reaches the next byte's contexts by following links rather than by searching; the context mixer holds approximate statistics in fixed tables. Independent blocks and conservative worker admission bound the live coding state.

On Silesia, CM reduces total size by 12.36% relative to `xz -9`, at 2.57 times the encoding CPU time and about 107 times the decoding CPU time. PPM produces 18.33% more bytes than CM and provides 7.58 and 7.24 times its encoding

and decoding throughput. The historical trie redesign more than halves coding time and maximum observed peak resident memory; the later combined model-and-coder revision saves a further 3.46% in bytes and 10.69% in encoding CPU time against its own trie baseline. These percentages come from separate experiments and are not composed; 7-Zip's PPMd remains 3.11% smaller and faster at the stated settings. A shorter repeat threshold enlarges CM's output, so reducing residual length alone is an insufficient selection criterion. On the held-out Census and Backblaze samples, CM is 5.7% and 4.0% smaller than `xz -9`, and the selected PPM is 4.9% and 5.0% larger than release 0.5.0's level 3. These measurements compare identified single-worker configurations; they do not establish parallel scaling.

References

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